registration certificate was not yet dry. It is written to a Parava trader, M.N. Gonsalves with business interests—mostly shipping cattle—in both Tuticorin and Colombo.[74]

> Dear brother,
>
> I … 4th inst …. steamer service, and so I have not written to you. As soon as the agreement is finished, I shall write to you.
>
> I thank you most … [pre]pared to undergo all trials … for our country.
>
> …
>
> I request you will try yourself and collect as many shares as you can. Copies of Memo. & Articles of Association & application forms are with Mr…. sami Pillai.

In this letter, VOC is addressing M.N. Gonsalves in familiar terms, calling him a brother. Invoking his personal friendship, VOC is urging him not only to take shares but also collect as many as he could. Even in this short letter, he is underlining the patriotic aspect of the venture and assuring him of his personal commitment to the cause of the country.

Many Tuticorin traders were summoned as witnesses in the sedition case against VOC. A key question posed by the prosecution to virtually all defence witnesses was their role in SSNCo and the number of shares they had taken in it.[75] From this we are able to collate the following information.

Sankaralinga Nadar (Defence Witness—DW 13), a forty-four-year-old commission agent and trader took fifteen shares, though he paid only the initial call of Rs 5. (He earned enough to pay an annual income tax of Rs 42.) A. Somasundara Pillai, a forty-one-year-old shopkeeper subscribed to twenty shares. M. Krishnaswamy Pillai (DW 16), a *gomasta* under Kuttalingam Pillai, himself a shareholder, took ten shares while his brother and partner, M. Sivasubramania Pillai bought an equal number. D. Narayanaswami Pillai (DW 18), aged thirty-eight and an exporter-trader, subscribed to a hundred shares. In the court he swore that he shipped his cargo exclusively on the Swadeshi steamers. Interestingly, he had been an accountant with S.V. Nallaperumal Pillai in the mid-1890s. V. Ganapathyappa Pillai (DW 34), a thirty-two-year-old pleader, affirmed that the family firm in which he had an interest held twenty shares. His brother-